

The Duquesne Christmas Mystery



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*** START OF THE PROJECT GUTENBERG EBOOK THE
DUQUESNE CHRISTMAS MYSTERY ***

Transcriber's Note:

Images of text in blackletter font were added where it appears in the original.

**THE DUQUESNE
CHRISTMAS MYSTERY**

THE DUQUESNE
CHRISTMAS MYSTERY

AS WRITTEN BY
THOMAS WOOD STEVENS
TO BE ENACTED BY THE PEOPLE OF
DUQUESNE PENNSYLVANIA
XXIII DECEMBER
MCMXVI



WITH DECORATIONS BY
HARRY LAWRENCE GAGE

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BEFORE US is a steep hillside, crossed midway by a paved road. Up the center of the hill are stairways of stone, with wide landings; at the top, blocking out the stars, is a dark building with crenellated turrets. Beside the roadway is a windowless hut—a mere blind wall—and at each side of this wall the stairways ascend. Below is a playing field, and beyond this, further down, a river, with great mills beside it, where even at Christmastide the loud forges are flaming.

From the high turrets a sound as of many trumpets floats down. Then a light breaks on the level above the roof of the hut, and one sees dimly three figures, grave, majestic, imperative—the Prophets Hosea, Micah, and Isaiah.

ISAIAH

List ye, as it is written, so spake I
Isaiah: For the Lord Himself shall send
Ye forth a sign; a virgin shall conceive,
And bear a son, and ye shall call his name
Immanuel.... And to thy light shall come
Gentiles, and kings unto the brightness of
Thy risen star.

MICAH

List ye, as it is written, so spake I,
Micah, prophet of God's will:
Thou, Bethlehem, though thou be little among

The thousands of Judah, out of thee shall come
Him who shall rule in Israel, whose path
Hath from of old been destined, everlasting.

HOSEA

List ye, as it is written, so spake I,
Hosea: When Israel was a child
I loved him well, and for his sake I called
My son out of dark Egypt.

ISAIAH

So spake we, prophets of the wandering years,
Lifting our hearts in hope to beat with God.
List ye, for He hath wrought our visions out,
And He hath sent His Son to feed His flock
Like to a shepherd. He hath gathered home
The lambs unto His bosom. Praise His name.

*The three Prophets disappear. Below, on
the hillside, three Eastern Kings are seen
approaching.*

JASPAR

Stay, brothers and princes. The star is lost.

BALTHASAR

Now for twelve nights it hath burned clear.

MELCHOIR

And floated on before to guide our steps.
Here is some evil thing that it should fade.

BALTHASAR

Some evil near. Stay we our course. The star
That westward we have trailed from Araby
And your bright orient kingdoms, will not fail
Until the prophecies we read of old
Be new fulfilled. But peril to the Child
Might dim its fire.

JASPAR

Yea, in the ancient scrolls
Are dangers written deep. The star-flame blows
Back at the heavy tread of mailed feet.

*Below, on the stairway, Herod appears,
and comes slowly up followed by guards
and counsellors.*

MELCHOIR

What gleam of helmets yonder, and of gold?

BALTHASAR

Some lord is this, whose rule is not as ours.

JASPAR

Hail, Prince, and peace, and light unto thy path!

HEROD

What stranger kings are these who come unknown,
Unbidden, to my realm?

BALTHASAR

From out the East
We come, Melchoir, and Jaspar, King of Taurus,
And he who speaks you here, Balthasar
Prince of Araby. We are come to seek
A Child new-born whose mystic star we found
As prophets had foretold from long ago,
A Child born to be King of the Jews. We come
With gifts to greet and worship Him. Say thou
Where is this Child?

HEROD

King of the Jews, ye say.
I know Him not.

JASPAR

Who art thou, good my lord?

HEROD

Forgive mine evil courtesy, sir princes,
But I am troubled.... Herod is my name, a king
In this lean land of Judah. Speak you fair,
And say again—this star—these prophecies?

JASPAR

The star hath led us westward, wondering on;
The prophecies name Bethlehem, a town
Little in Judah, whence shall come a King
To rule in Israel, anoint of God.

HEROD

I knew it not. I have no child.... But when
First saw ye this new star?

BALTHASAR

Twelve nights ago.
'Tis like the Child was born that night.

HEROD

Yea, very like, and have ye told me all?

BALTHASAR

All that hath been revealed. We wait
Here with our gifts. The star may burn again.

HEROD

My greetings, Princes. Freedoms of my realm
Be yours. But this I pray you, when you find
The Child indeed, bring me straight word of it.
For I would worship also.

JASPAR

Peace be thine.

*Herod goes down the stair, and pauses at
the central landing, his spearmen and
counsellors about him.*

HEROD

Dreams and seditions! When these kings return,
These dark intruding Magi, with their babe,
Bring them before me. They adventure far
But I will send them on a longer quest.

A COUNSELLOR

Whither wilt send them, Tetrarch?

HEROD

Unto death.
For all their dreams are treason 'gainst my house.

COUNSELLOR

And if they do not find the child?

HEROD

Still—death.
For they have mocked me, searching.

COUNSELLOR

And the child?

HEROD

Hear ye my sentence: if they find this child,
He dies. And if they find him not, but slip
Out of my hands unrecompensed, then all
Men children of this young child's year, shall die,
That he escape not.

COUNSELLOR

These be bloody words.

HEROD

I have my prophets too. Wouldst flout their law
And mine? Set on.

*Herod and his people move slowly down
the stairways into darkness. In radiance*

*above the center appears the Messenger
Gabriel.*

GABRIEL

The watchers of the skies, God's messengers,
Keep ward upon this land to-night. The tyrant
Speaketh true: the olden words shall fall
Like blades of harvest on the innocents
And Rachael weep, and weep un comforted.
So it is written. But the child they seek
Dies not, but waits his agony, serene
Amid the singing of the morning stars.

*The Gloria in Excelsis is heard afar off.
At the left, on the hillside, a faint light
glows upon a group of watching
shepherds. As the light brightens, they
hear the heavenly voices, see the angel,
and, struck with awe, fall upon their
knees.*

GABRIEL

**Fear not, for behold I bring you good tidings of
great joy, which shall be to all people.
For unto you is born this day, in the city of David,
a Saviour which is Christ the Lord.
And this shall be a sign unto you: He shall find
the babe wrapped in swaddling clothes, lying in a
manger.**

Fear not, for behold I bring you good tidings of

great joy, which shall be to all people.
For unto you is born this day, in the city of David,
a Saviour which is Christ the Lord.
And this shall be a sign unto you: Ye shall find
the babe wrapped in swaddling clothes, lying in a manger.

*The shepherds gather wondering, as the
heavenly messenger disappears and the
chorus echoes into silence.*

FIRST SHEPHERD

Saw ye, my brothers?

SECOND SHEPHERD

Yea truly, and marveled.

THIRD SHEPHERD

And lo, our people come now from the hills
With wonder upon them.

SECOND SHEPHERD

Let the sheep graze alone. The Lord his hand
Is over us and all our flocks to-night.

FIRST SHEPHERD

This we have seen is in God's will. And men
Hearing of us this strange new word, will come
From far to kneel adoring,—all such men
As we who toil and watch. Not unto captains
Of wrath, high lords, and governors of cities
Did he speak, but unto simple folk he came
And cried his tidings of great joy. To us

God's messenger doth pledge a Saviour Christ,
And they who toil and watch, shall know of it.

*He turns toward the windowless wall at
the center.*

**Let us go now unto Bethlehem and see the thing
which is come to pass, which the Lord hath made
known unto us.**

Let us go now unto Bethlehem and see the thing which is come to pass,
which the Lord hath made known unto us.

*Again the trumpets sound, and a mighty music of voices aspires as the
thronging messengers of heaven appear along the central causeway. Before
them, above the windowless wall, a star swings magically into flame. The
Shepherds and the Eastern Kings move toward the star, enwrapt and silent.*

*Now the wall seems suddenly to vanish. In its place, filled with a golden
radiance, is the manger, and Mary the Mother holding the Child.*

*The Shepherds kneel in adoration; and the Kings lay at her feet their
gifts, gold, frankincense and myrrh.*

*Up from below come slowly the men and women of the nations who
dwell in the city, they too kneeling till the stairways are dark with them; and
all the while the music swells with a great gladness.*

*The vision fades, and the people turn singing to the darkness below,
where the forges are clanging.*

*And now the Tree on the playing field breaks into light, and down the
stone stairways patter the feet of many children, trooping with song to
dance around its glistening spire.*

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CHRISTMAS MYSTERY ***

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